phoned Victoria. I phoned Mum and Dad. Something like this hasn't really happened until you've shared it with your family. And then, still sat on the bed, I found myself thinking: *It's fantastic. But I don't want to be England captain just for one game. I want the job to keep.*

Once that was in my mind, I calmed down a bit. I didn't run in and jump up and down on Gary's bed. We had breakfast later and I just told him what had happened, almost matter-of-factly:

'Oh, by the way Gaz. I've been made England captain. Pass the cornflakes.'

I must admit I'd always seen Gary as a captain, either at United or with England. As it turned out, it happened to me first. He was as pleased for me as I'd have been for him. It was some way to start a day before the drive in to train. I think the news got to Carrington before I did and I got some grief from the United lads, who insisted on calling me 'Skipper' for the rest of the morning.

I didn't really talk to anyone about how to approach the captain's job. I'd seen how other people did it. I knew my own character, and that I had to find my own way. I realized that the shouting and hollering wouldn't be for me. It was going to have to be about going out there and playing, working hard, and hoping to lead by example. Joining up with the rest of the squad for the first time as captain was great. The whole experience was, even though I put myself under pressure: I couldn't just relax and enjoy the moment because I was aware, the whole time, that I didn't want this to be a one time only thing. I had to try to make sure that a new full-time manager would agree with the decision Peter Taylor had made.

I was delighted Peter had given me the armband and, in hindsight, I'm grateful that he picked the squad he did too. I was captaining a young side: I felt I had the experience and that I could take that extra responsibility. It might not have seemed so natural a progression if senior players like Paul Ince, Tony Adams or Alan Shearer, who'd been captains themselves, had still been involved. I might not have taken things so much in my stride. Even so, some people weren't sure about me in the role. It helped that Peter made it clear he believed in me. It felt like my team-mates did too. There were enough really young lads around for me to feel like an old man in the England set-up.

Leading the team out against Italy—never mind it was an exhibition, never mind the stands weren't full—was one of the proudest moments of my